



releasing funds for Gujarat's development. But these funds belong to public treasury and have not been brought by Sonia *behen* as dowry from Italy."

The Congress is not short on muck-rakers, either. Shankarsinh Vaghela does not hesitate to call Modi a "butcher capable of engineering the killing of anybody to win an election". Last week, he accused the chief minister of getting BJP leader Haren Pandya murdered in 2003 and the Sangh Parivar of setting the Sabarmati Express afire at Godhra on February 27 2002—where Ram sevaks were killed—in order to trigger a sympathy wave in their favour. "They could do any such thing again to win this poll," says Vaghela. Not surprisingly, among the many pamphlets being readied by the Congress is one, which warns people that a Godhra-like incident might be orchestrated by BJP on the eve of the Assembly polls.

Trial runs of provocative politics are

already being held though it is not certain who is behind them. At Surat last week, several scooters belonging to people who had come to hear Modi at a public meeting were set aflame minutes after Modi concluded his speech. Enraged, Modi dared his opponents: "If you have the guts, come and burn me, but why vent your anger on my innocent supporters." The Congress later alleged the incident was stage-managed by Modi himself to gain sympathy on the election eve and demanded a CBI inquiry into it.

In a state where the dividing line between politicians and religious saints is wafer-thin, sadhus have also got into the act. One set of them opposed to Modi paint him as Ravana. "After taking votes in the name of Ram, it is Ravana who is ruling in Gandhinagar today," said one sadhu. In fact, Ravana is the most common epithet hurled at Modi by his opponents. Last week being Dussehra, several effigies of Modi were also burnt in the state.

Once the dust settles, the campaign will go down as one of the dirtiest in Gujarat's history. However, it remains to be seen who gains from it. ■

"People do not know which gutter Modi was born in and who fathered him."

B.K. HARIPRASAD, CONGRESS LEADER

Visit us at www.steelforlife.net

Open your eyes to
the wonders of steel



It's time you made a fashion statement, giving your home a new look with steel. Anything made of steel - from the lightest to the largest, from the lightest to the heaviest - has its own way of making people sit up and take notice. Be it furniture, panels, windows or doors. Durable, low cost and easy to fabricate, steel adds a touch of class to your home.



PROMOTED BY:

